



Navigate expectation and realistic project goals

We discussed before how data has limitations. Sometimes you don't have access to the data you need, or your data sources aren't aligned or your data is unclear. This can definitely be a problem when you're analyzing data, but it can also affect your communication with your stakeholders. That's why **it's important to balance your stakeholders' expectations with what is actually possible for a project**. We're going to learn about the importance of setting realistic, objective goals and how to best communicate with your stakeholders about problems you might run into. Keep in mind that a lot of things depend on your analysis. Maybe your team can't make a decision without your report. Or maybe your initial data work will determine how and where additional data will be gathered. You might remember that we've talked about some situations where it's important to loop stakeholders in. For example, telling your project manager if you're on schedule or if you're having a problem. Now, let's look at a real-life example where you need to communicate with stakeholders and what you might do if you run into a problem. Let's say you're working on a project for an insurance company. The company wants to identify common causes of minor car accidents so that they can develop educational materials that encourage safer driving. There's a few early questions you and your team need to answer. **What driving habits will you include in your dataset? How will you gather this data? How long will it take you to collect and clean that data before you can use it in your analysis?** Right away you want to

communicate clearly with your stakeholders to answer these questions, so you and your team can set a reasonable and realistic timeline for the project. It can be tempting to tell your stakeholders that you'll have this done in no time, no problem. But setting expectations for a realistic timeline will help you in the long run. Your stakeholders will know what to expect when, and you won't be overworking yourself and missing deadlines because you overpromised. I find that setting expectations early helps me spend my time more productively. So as you're getting started, you'll want to send a high-level schedule with different phases of the project and their approximate start dates. In this case, you and your teams establish that you'll need three weeks to complete analysis and provide recommendations, and you let your stakeholders know so they can plan accordingly. Now let's imagine you're further along in the project and you run into a problem. Maybe drivers have opted into sharing data about their phone usage in the car, but you discover that some sources count GPS usage, and some don't in their data. This might add time to your data processing and cleaning and delay some project milestones. You'll want to let your project manager know and maybe work out a new timeline to present to stakeholders. The earlier you can flag these problems, the better. That way your stakeholders can make necessary changes as soon as possible. Or what if your stakeholders want to add car model or age as possible variables. You'll have to communicate with them about how that might change the model you've built, if it can be added and before the deadlines, and any other obstacles that they need to know so they can decide if it's worth changing at this stage of the project. To help them you might prepare a report on how their request changes the project timeline or alters the model. You could also outline the pros and cons of that change. You want to help your

stakeholders achieve their goals, but it's important to set realistic expectations at every stage of the project. This takes some balance. You've learned about balancing the needs of your team members and stakeholders, but you also need to balance stakeholder expectations and what's possible with the projects, resources, and limitations. That's why it's important to be realistic and objective and communicate clearly. This will help stakeholders understand the timeline and have confidence in your ability to achieve those goals. So we know communication is key and we have some good rules to follow for our professional communication. Coming up we'll talk even more about answering stakeholder questions, delivering data and communicating with your team.